

HOME IS WHERE THE HEART IS

"I believe that what makes Offspring special is that it gives voice to every individual's unforgotten story, deeply entrenched with the very human emotions of family love and separation," said Sandeep M. Bhatnagar while throwing light on his debut novel - Offspring.

Initially set in the early 1900s in British India when travel abroad was unheard of for common man and some thought that crossing the seven seas was a sin, Offspring follows the life journey of young Rohan, who travels to Australia for further studies. This means bearing the pain of separation from his beloved parents and elder brother but Rohan is determined to return home.

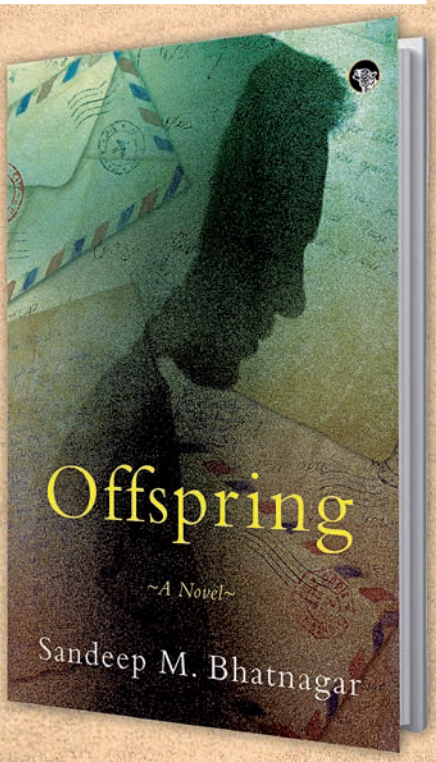
The story then takes an interesting unforeseen turn when he falls in love with Jenny, his Professor's niece, and follows her further away all the while trying to convince her to move with him to Ambala. But Jenny finally declines and Rohan unwillingly settles abroad grappling with the guilt of forsaking his family and birthplace. Offspring's enigmatic ending leaves it to the reader to decide whether Rohan indeed did something wrong by settling abroad, far from his birthplace.

"The story is personal in a way since we all migrate from one place to another or know someone dear who has done so," explained Sandeep, "When I was posted at the Indian Consulate in New York from 2003 to 2007, I met scores of people belonging to the Indian diaspora. I found it interesting that though most had done exceedingly well in their new home, they would always reminisce about their birthplaces and the near and dear ones they had left behind with a sense of deep loss."

And thus was born Sandeep's inspiration to pen this tale, over the time adding fictional elements underlined with his real-life experience. But of course as a bureaucrat engaged full time with several key reforms in the field of Customs, Central Excise and GST, Sandeep could not spare the time to do so. He got this opportunity when he superannuated in August, 2021, from the post of Member, Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs, Government of India.

Scripting the story was not new to Sandeep. True to the title of this novel, the gift of writing has been transmitted from father to offspring. He is the son of Late Meem Meem Rajinder, a celebrated Urdu fiction writer. Sandeep's first fictional book too many years back was in Urdu, a collection of short stories for children, titled - Ek Naya Afsana. Sandeep also has bestsellers on indirect tax policies for export units and special economic zones.

Like any offspring, did this author fear being compared to his renowned father? "It is perhaps difficult to find a reader, who has read my father's books during his prime, and is probably reading me now. Within the family, my writing style is always seen as being very similar to his. I am glad my children got to read the book to see a different side to their father," he replied.



They say, family is everything, isn't it? Offspring is a memorable testament to this truism and being a fictional rendition of every man's life story, it would resonate with the reader.

Offspring is published by Speaking Tiger, Delhi. It is available on Amazon including Kindle, WOB, Bokus, Barnes & Nobles, Bahari Sons, Midland, Full Circle, Jain Book Agency, Granth, Kitab Khana, Book Lovers, Roxy Book Store, The Book Shop and other major web portals and book stores world-wide.